

Text One

Why it's so important to celebrate life's milestones

adapted from an article by Hannah Keegan

In this passage, the writer presents her ideas about why it is important for people to celebrate.



For centuries, the way we choose to mark occasions has mattered. Think of the birthdays, weddings, anniversaries and national holidays that are scattered across your calendar every year. The hours you have spent thinking about the gifts you've bought for the people you love – to congratulate, celebrate and show affection for them when they get promoted or hit a new goal.

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Birthdays first became 'A Thing' in Ancient Egypt. When pharaohs were crowned, they were believed to be reborn as gods, making their coronation date their birthday and they were celebrated as such: with a big party.

The first ever reference to a birthday appears in the Bible when a pharaoh is described as holding a feast in celebration, around 3,000 BCE. The first record of an invitation to a birthday party was written in Latin on a wooden tablet by a Roman woman, Claudia Severa, to a commander's wife around 100 CE. It read, 'On 11 September, sister, for the day of the celebration of my birthday, I give you a warm invitation to make sure that you come to us, to make the day more enjoyable for me by your arrival, if you are present.' In short: please come to my party. Later, it became customary to give someone celebrating their 50th birthday a special cake made of wheat flour, olive oil, honey and grated cheese. But women's birthdays weren't generally celebrated until around the 12th century.

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But whether it's a birthday, Eid¹ or a career milestone that we're celebrating, where does our urge to rejoice collectively actually come from?

According to psychotherapist Dr Sheri Jacobson of Harley Therapy, it's innate. 'It's part of the human experience to mark the times of positive and negative change,' she explains. 'On the celebratory side, this involves birthdays, marriages, achievements and awards, but on the other hand, it's about coming together around times of loss, too.' 20

'Community plays a big part in this because we are fundamentally social creatures. Evolution and psychology tell us that we are built for living in small communities and, while we're far more networked these days, and our circle of influences are much wider, we still need other people for survival. Celebrations reinforce the community network and allow us to get to know people better. Even trauma bonds people during these occasions because it reinforces social ties and empathy.' 25

Times of uncertainty can be more stressful than plain bad news, and this is actually when we'll most benefit from taking part in celebrations. 'This is because when we are low we often find ourselves with our darker thoughts and withdrawing from company,' Jacobson explains. 'And one of the antidotes to low mood and anxiety is to surround ourselves with people who we feel comfortable around. Besides reinforcing community ties, it's also very beneficial on an individual level because it gives us a chemical boost.' 30 35

'There are various feel-good chemicals at work here. There's adrenaline – which we get in surges and which isn't particularly good for us over prolonged periods of time. There's serotonin, which is a softer form of elevation. And then there are endorphins, which come about through achievements and socialising.'

Let's not forget that the common thing to do when we're celebrating someone's achievements is to give them a hug, and for good reason. 'In the western world, we've become really tuned into our mental health and we understand the benefits of talking and sharing with loved ones, and therapists, but we're less conscious of the healing benefits of physical touch,' says Jacobson. 'A chemical called oxytocin is released during a hug or physical contact and it's basically a stress reliever; cortisol – which is stress-causing – is also reduced.' So we're actually prolonging that feeling of wellbeing on receiving good news or celebrating a holiday. 40 45

So then, when it comes to marking an occasion, how do we approach it mindfully? For psychologist Pamela Jacobsen, of the Bath Centre for Mindfulness and Compassion, it comes back to gratitude. 'Most of us go through life on automatic pilot – it's a habitual way of responding to our experience – and this prevents us from experiencing in-the-moment joy,' she explains. 'When we talk about celebrations, we're essentially talking about being grateful for the things we have in our life. A wedding or religious holiday, for example, is about expressing gratitude for the people you love and the opportunity of being with them. Tuning into that sense of gratitude can make the experience much richer.' 50 55

Getting together to celebrate the passage of time is an important tradition. As consumer psychologist Patrick Fagan puts it, 'It's cathartic². People overeat, party, dress up, which is a deviation from normal social order,' he says. 'Most importantly, it's life-affirming. It's about marking the passage of time and bringing structure to a world which is chaotic and frightening.' At a time when a lot feels uncertain, enjoying how far you've come is about as uplifting as it gets. 60

*Eid*¹ – a worldwide festival for Muslims that occurs twice a year

*cathartic*² – helpful/beneficial

Text Two

Why Do We Celebrate New Year's Eve? The Importance of New Beginnings

adapted from a blog by Shannon Sweeney

In this passage, the American writer presents her ideas about celebrating the New Year by making positive changes.



The New Year is one of the world's oldest-celebrated holidays — our society has commemorated New Year's Eve since 2000 BC, according to the website Earth Sky. They report that it started as an 11-day festival, so if you're struggling with one night of celebrating, imagine *eleven*. Since then, this 4,000-year-old holiday has evolved into what it is today.

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But why is New Year's Eve really worth celebrating? For many people, it's more than an excuse to dress up and go out — it's a symbol for starting over. It's a precise moment for leaving some things in the past while embracing change and challenges. New Year's Eve also gives us the chance to reflect on the previous year, because most of us are different people than we were 365 days ago.

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So when we're celebrating New Year's Eve what we're really celebrating are the positive changes we've made and the chance at a new beginning. The new year represents the possibility to become happier and healthier, not because crossing the midnight threshold on December 31st creates some kind of magic, but because the turn of the calendar year inherently allows for a mental reset.

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The first step to becoming happier often means changing the way we think.

New Beginnings Mean You Can Try Something That Makes You Happy

Having a new beginning may be as simple as trying something new that makes you happy. This could be a popular resolution like working out more or eating better — these things do, over time, tend to make people healthier and happier. But if that's not your thing, don't force it! There are so many different ways the new year can bring you happiness.

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For instance, a new hobby. This could be reading more, taking more photos, crafting, cooking, or another solo activity that allows you to gain new skills and explore your creative side. It could also include more social activities like joining a club or an organization with people who have similar interests. Try something new that scares you a little; the best things happen outside of your comfort zone. Last year, I made a resolution to eat out less, and it wasn't until then that I realized how much I genuinely love cooking and how much it makes me happy. Which leads me to the next point...

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New Beginnings Are A Chance To Give Things Up That Make You Unhappy

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Stop doing things that make you unhappy. A resolution doesn't have to be adding something, it can be taking something away. Giving up unhealthy attachments or breaking a bad habit is a great way to start over. Quitting smoking and cutting back on drinking are both fairly common and totally respectable resolutions. But the things you give up don't have to be just clear and extreme negative influences. Sometimes the things you need to let go of take on more subtle forms. If you don't like going to the gym, try a new way to stay active like hiking, a sport, or an exercise class. If being on social media makes you unhappy, take a break or consciously limit the time you spend on social platforms. The new year is a great time to give up anything that's holding you back. Unpacking a little emotional baggage is a great way to travel forward.

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New Beginnings Allow For Setting New, Attainable Goals

Make goals that are measurable and attainable. Whatever you want to get done, put a plan in place first. A majority of people quit on long-term resolutions because they don't have a strategy to succeed. Just remember, you can't do it all at once – you have 365 days to accomplish a goal: it just takes dedication and preparation.

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New Beginnings Are A Time To Start Prioritizing You

The importance of a fresh start means you can start targeting areas of self-care that are lacking. No matter what it is, take time out of your schedule to take care of you. Self-care starts with actually doing it – set an hour a day, a day of the week, or a few days a month, to focus on you and your well-being. This will help you escape the day-to-day routine of wake-up, work, eat, sleep, repeat.

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New Beginnings Can Launch Long-Term Action

The beginning of the year is a perfect place to start, but this year may not be the time to finish. Sometimes the things we need to accomplish will take much longer than 12 months. Whether you're trying to pick up a new habit or break an old one, the most important part of a new year/new beginning mentality is that you create a plan for success and stick to it. For some it also helps to create rewards for yourself as you hit milestones along the way. A plan, a support system and a desire for meaningful change will keep you motivated far beyond the end of January.

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